> "The force on your body goes up to over 4G, which means the pressure you feel is four times your body weight. It is as if somebody is pushing you hard against your seat, especially across your chest. Everything, including your lungs, feels compressed, making it difficult to breathe"

Q. What happened when the rockets ignited?
In my head, I had imagined what it would feel like. Having been a fighter pilot most of my life, I do have experience of sitting atop a jet engine. But when the Falcon's Merlin engines ignited, everything I had imagined completely went out the window. It was extremely powerful and very quick. My first thought was—this is something else. Everything shakes because of the engine's vibrations. You feel it inside your body as well—every bone feels shaken when those engines come on.

Q. When watching the spaceship take off, it sounded like 30 jet engines firing simultaneously. What did it sound like inside the spacecraft?
If all that sound were to reach inside the capsule, it would be beyond human endurance. There are a lot of ways in which this sound is subdued. We wear specially moulded earpieces that fit snugly. On top of that, you are wearing a space suit helmet, which also mitigates the sound. And the Dragon Crew capsule itself in which we are sitting is acoustically designed to minimise noise from the outside. So, it is not so loud.

Q. When you lift off, your spacecraft goes from zero to 28,000 kmph, around 22 times the speed of sound. What happens to your body during this rapid acceleration?
When you see a spaceship take off, it appears slow and gradual. But inside, things are happening extremely fast. As pilot of the mission, I was supposed to monitor the displays and the parameters. But when we lifted off, I found myself lagging because I had not imagined it to be that quick. It took me about 20 seconds to catch up with what was happening. The acceleration builds from zero to 28,000 km in just eight and a half minutes and the force on your body goes up to over 4G, which means the pressure you feel is four times your body weight. It is as if somebody is pushing you hard against your seat, especially across your chest. Everything, including your lungs, feels compressed, making it difficult to breathe. But this was a familiar aspect for me because I have handled excessive G-forces in my career as a fighter pilot.



> "When we were free from gravity for the first time, we shouted and screamed like kids. Our commander had to tell us to quieten down to listen to ground control. It was a real fun ride"

Q. What did your first experience of near-zero gravity feel like?
It was an incredibly surreal moment. There is all this chaos—the powerful rocket engines igniting, the launch and rapid acceleration, the G-force rising. And then, suddenly, nothing. It is just so peaceful. One moment, you were being pushed into your seat and the next everything stops. Gradually, you start floating, because you are in microgravity. Although you are strapped in, you can feel your body is not touching the seat and your hands are floating upwards. You are experiencing something for the first time, and it is beautiful. Not just for me but for my other two crew-mates too, who were also in space for the first time. We shouted and screamed like kids, so much so that our commander had to tell us to quieten down so that we could listen to ground control. It was a real fun ride. You have left the planet where you have always been and, for the first time, you are looking back at Earth from the outside. It is a feeling unlike any other.